6. Chinese Pilgrims Journey to the ‘West’ and Diplomatic Missions Follow

During the first millennium there was a steady stream of Chinese Buddhist monks visiting the sacred places in India associated with Lord Buddha. They were not only on pilgrimage but also in search of the ‘authentic’ version of their faith, gathering original scriptures in Pali and in Sanskrit and learning at the feet of great masters in India’s reputed monasteries and monastic schools, among them Nalanda, Taxila and Vikramshila.

These journeys spanned the entire first millennium, but halted thereafter. There were several reasons for this. From the beginning of the second millennium, India fell under a succession of Muslim rulers hostile to both the Hindu and Buddhist faiths. The land routes through Central Asia came under Arab rule, interrupting the old caravan trails from China. Buddhism was already in decline in India from the middle of the first millennium, and this is evident from the accounts of the Chinese pilgrims.

By the end of the first millennium, few of its traces remained in its country of origin, and it would have been hard to find many adherents left. A revived Hindu faith had managed to absorb many of the remnants of the faith in its fold, while Buddhism also began to absorb many Hindu influences.

This was most apparent in the growth of Tantric Buddhism in the eastern parts of India, which borrowed heavily from the Shaivite and Shakti cults that were becoming increasingly popular. It is this esoteric form, with its magical spells and powerful deities, which then took root in Tibet. These Buddhist deities, some of whom were borrowed from the Hindu faith, constituted a whole new pantheon of gods and goddesses, some fierce and some benign and gentle. The use of ‘mandalas’, or visual representations of different theological and philosophical ideas, also became part of Tantric Buddhism. As in the Hindu version of Tantrism, the Buddhist variety also